

workload. One day, out of curiosity I asked her why she wasn't off enjoying her retirement, why was she working here? She told me honestly that she couldn't afford not to work. She lived alone and needed to pay her rent and buy food. She told me that when she was younger, despite working for many years, she didn't save at all. She didn't really think about it and instead left all financial matters for her husband to manage. When he passed away, she was left with very little money and no assets. Her children were not in a position to help her and she had no desire to be in a state-funded nursing home, and so she was there working with me at that store. It broke my heart to see her struggling with her tasks every day because at her age, she should have been enjoying her retirement instead of standing on her feet for eight-hour shifts helping sometimes rude customers and earning minimum wage. It didn't take long for me to get a full-time job and leave that store, but I took away a valuable lesson—I didn't ever want to find myself in that position when I got older. This is just one example of the importance of saving for retirement as early as you can.

When it comes to retiring early to live life on your own terms, a completely different story is that of my close friend, Kalyn Johnson Chandler, founder and creative director of Effie's Paper: Stationery & Whatnot (effiespaper.com). She was able to retire early as a result of smart planning and went on to start her own business, which she runs successfully today. I asked her to share some insights on how she made it happen. Here's what she shared: